

Introduction to Hegemony

Hegemony is an asymmetric, card-driven, political-economic game that simulates the complexities of an entire nation. It offers a unique and dynamic experience of managing a country, as the players embody the different socio-economic groups found in any society. Each player represents one of four factions: the Working Class, the Capitalist Class, the Middle Class, or the State. The aim of the game is simple: lead your class to victory by gaining the most points, by the end of the 5th round. However, this goal becomes increasingly complex as players interact, negotiate, compete, co-operate, and make strategic decisions based on their class's interests - which increasingly conflict with the interests of the other players.

In Hegemony, each player takes on the role of a socio-economic group:

- **The Working Class:** Controls workers, sends them to work for wages, and uses income to cover their basic needs (e.g., food, health, education). Their goal is to secure better wages and benefits.
- **The Capitalist Class:** Owns and operates companies, employs workers, and aims to maximize profits. They push for lower taxes and fewer regulations to increase profitability.
- **The Middle Class:** Balances roles between working for wages and managing small businesses. They engage in both production and consumption to find the right balance.
- **The State:** Strives to maintain stability, provide benefits, and manage public services (e.g., health, education, media). The State aims to maintain the legitimacy of its policies and respond to crises.

Each class has its own set of unique goals and strategies. The game is deeply interconnected, with all players influencing each other through political actions and policy changes.

Game Structure and Phases

The game is played over **5 rounds**, each consisting of several phases that highlight the interconnectedness of the socio-economic groups. Here's what happens in each phase:

- **Preparation Phase:** This phase begins each round (except the first). Players set up the board, refresh their resources, and prepare for action.
- **Action Phase:** Players take turns in the sequence of **Working Class → Middle Class → Capitalist Class → State**. Each player has a hand of 7 cards and plays 5 of these per round. On their turn, players can choose to:
 - Perform the **card's action**, often advancing their class-specific goals.
 - Use a **Basic Action**, which is simpler and universally available.
 - Use a **Free Action**, which doesn't consume their turn.For example:

- The Working Class can propose bills to parliament, assign workers to jobs, or buy goods and services.
 - The Capitalist Class can build companies, sell to foreign markets, or negotiate business deals.
 - The Middle Class shares some actions with other groups but also has unique mechanics, such as utilizing extra shifts.
 - The State manages political campaigns, events, and taxation while balancing legitimacy and public services.
- **Production Phase:** Players manage their resources based on their class:
 - **The Capitalist Class** runs companies to produce goods and generate revenue.
 - **The Working Class** earns wages and spends on goods and services to cover basic needs like food, health, and education.
 - **The State** collects taxes, supports public companies, and checks on the International Monetary Fund (IMF) status.
 - **The Middle Class** balances production from their businesses with their consumption needs.
 - **Election Phase:** Players propose and vote on **Policies**, using **Influence** and **Immediate Votes** to steer the direction of the State. The results can shift the ideological landscape of the entire nation, affecting taxation, public services, and market regulations for all classes.
 - **Scoring Phase:** At the end of each round, players earn points based on their class-specific objectives. For example:
 - The Working Class measures their prosperity and well-being.
 - The Capitalist Class focuses on their profits and market dominance.
 - The Middle Class balances its dual role of labor and small business management.
 - The State scores based on its ability to maintain stability and support public services.

The **Politics Table** ties everything together, with three key sections representing taxation, public services, and market regulation. Throughout the game, Policies enacted here will shape the interactions between players, creating new challenges and opportunities.

Educational Value of Hegemony

1. Understanding Socio-Economic Systems

Hegemony provides an interactive way to learn about different socio-economic systems and the policies that govern them, how classes in a society cooperate and compete, and the challenges facing State institutions in maintaining a functional society. By taking on the roles of different classes, players gain insight into how decisions made by one group impact others. For example:

- The **Working Class** develops an understanding of how wages and job conditions affect their well-being.
- The **Capitalist Class** learns how to run businesses efficiently, including managing costs (e.g., wages, taxes, and investments) and maximizing revenues to achieve profitability.
- The **Middle Class** navigates the challenges of balancing wage work with entrepreneurship, skillfully managing smaller businesses while addressing their consumption needs.
- The **State** explores the role of governance, taxation, and public services.

This dynamic gives players a practical understanding of the economic and political landscape of a nation, and first-hand experience of how different groups within society try to pursue their goals against the opposing interests of other groups.

2. Debating and Shaping Policy

A key component of the game involves **parliament** and **policy-making**. Players need to lobby, negotiate, and team up to pass policies that benefit their class. The game explains ideological concepts such as:

- **Socialism**: Focuses on public control over essential services like healthcare and education.
- **Neoliberalism**: Advocating for privatization, low taxation, and less government involvement.
- **Mixed Economy**: Combining elements of both socialism and neoliberalism.

Through this, players learn how rules can change society and the economy. They learn about political ideologies, how these ideas work in real-world political systems, and how different groups pursue different, often competing, agendas to maximise their own interests (frequently at the expense of others).

3. Ideological Movements and Shifting Alliances

As players interact, the country's direction can change toward socialism, neoliberalism, or a mixed economy. The game keeps changing, so players must adjust to new situations and form new alliances to succeed. The game also shows how lobbying works in real-world politics, teaching players about the strategies needed to influence decisions and policy outcomes.

4. Real-World Political and Economic Concepts

By engaging with Hegemony, players learn about key political and economic concepts that are actively debated in the real world. These include:

- **Market structures**: How different markets operate and how government policies affect them.

- **Fiscal policy:** The role of government spending and taxation in managing the economy.
- **Political lobbying:** How interest groups work to influence decisions to benefit their own socio-economic interests.

The game also uses concepts from great political theorists, including **Gramsci**, **Keynes**, **Friedman**, and **Marx**, to help players understand these real-world ideas in a fun and simple way. Through this system, players can better see how policies influence socio-economic structures. They also learn about different political ideologies and how these ideas show up in real-world political systems.

5. Educational Booklet: "Concepts"

To enhance the educational value, during the Kickstarter the game included the educational booklet **Concepts**. This booklet explains key terms and theories from political economy, political science, and economics. It serves as a guide for players, helping them understand the deeper academic concepts behind the game and how they relate to real-world political events and decisions. You can find the theories of Concepts on our online knowledge base [here](#).

Adapting Hegemony to a Classroom Environment

Hegemony is an excellent tool for classroom learning and can be adapted to suit educational goals. The game provides a way to explore political, economic, and social theories in an entertaining and interactive way. Teachers can use the game to:

- **Pose questions:** Encourage students to engage with complex issues by posing questions like:
 - What is the goal of each class and how do they achieve it?
 - How does the policy on taxation affect the working class versus the capitalist class?
 - What happens when the nation shifts towards neoliberalism?
 - Why do some states face economic collapse, and what are the key factors behind it? What happens after this?
 - Why might one social group support a policy while another opposes it?
 - What happens if a country opens or closes its borders to people or goods?
 - Can classes work together to achieve shared goals? Or is conflict between classes inevitable?
- **Present real-world examples:** Teachers can compare in-game events to historical or current political events, helping students understand the impact of different policies through 'real-world' examples.
- **Explore interdependencies:** As students play, they can see how decisions made by one group affect others, helping them understand how political and economic

systems are linked.

By integrating these thought-provoking questions and comparisons, Hegemony becomes a dynamic and educational experience, fostering deeper understanding and discussion of real-world political and economic systems.

This hands-on approach lets students experience the challenges of political and economic systems, facilitating discussions on topics such as taxation, labor rights, market dynamics, and policy-making. Traditional classroom learning can sometimes only go so far, and an interactive game is a great way to get students deeply involved in the subject while encouraging them to think critically, and discuss and appreciate different viewpoints.

Hegemony is more than just a game. It's a learning tool that helps people understand socio-economic systems, political ideas, and the interconnectedness of different societal groups. By taking on the roles of the Working Class, the Capitalist Class, the Middle Class, and the State, players gain practical knowledge about the realities of how political and economic decisions are made, and how these decisions affect everyone in society.

With its combination of strategic gameplay and educational depth, Hegemony is an engaging way to explore and understand complicated political and economic topics. This makes it a valuable tool for teaching, both in classrooms and in other settings.